# Rising Sun Martial Arts Academy

*Only through experience can you understand and cultivate presence in your practice.*

## Essential Points of Our Taichi Practice - Taijiquan

## 1. Empty, Agile, and Aware Energy Reaches the Crown

I'd like to begin discussing Essential Points. Regardless of lineage, these principles are foundational. Different traditions may interpret them differently, and our understanding naturally deepens over time. What these principles mean at one stage of training often differs from what they reveal years later.

The first point is usually translated as:

> "Empty, agile, and aware
> energy reaches the crown."

It is also commonly explained as "suspending the head from above."

These descriptions point to the same principle, but at different levels of understanding.

At the most basic physical level, the instruction is to suspend from above. This does not mean pushing the head upward. Rather, it means hanging from above.

The cranium is organized correctly, the neck opens, and the body hangs naturally from the crown point. The body opens without being forced open.

Imagine an anatomical skeleton suspended from a hook. Gravity gently separates and opens each joint. The structure lengthens naturally without effort. This is the quality we seek.

The crown is lifted, but the body is not pushing upward. Because the body hangs from above, it can simultaneously settle below. The body becomes sunk but not lowered. Relaxed, but not collapsed. Open, but not stretched.

This creates a neutral and balanced state.

However, if we examine the actual wording, we see that the point is something more subtle than posture alone. It is something light, empty, agile, and aware reaching the crown. This is not merely a mechanical position.

The physical suspension of the body is only the prerequisite.

Once the body is suspended correctly, qi naturally descends and sinks. As it descends, it fills the legs and feet. As it settles into the dantian, it accumulates and develops fullness. This sinking generates complementary forces. Descending creates rising. Sinking creates filling.

The union of these paired processes produces a light, buoyant quality throughout the body.

Over time, a subtle force rises through the body's center and reaches the crown. This is the deeper meaning of "empty, agile, and aware energy reaching the crown."

It is not something we directly do. It is something that emerges from proper causes.

First comes physical organization. Later comes energetic development. Finally, those energetic processes influence consciousness itself.

This is why beginners start by adjusting the head and cervical spine, opening the neck, and establishing correct structure.

Initially, we can only sink the flesh and relax the tissues. Qi is not yet clearly perceived. As practice matures, qi becomes more apparent. We learn to sink the qi rather than merely relax the body. As this process deepens and transforms us, the vital spirit naturally rises and reaches the crown.

These are not actions we impose. They are effects arising from correct causes.

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## 2. Contain the Chest and Raise the Back

The second essential point is usually translated:

> "Contain the chest and raise the back."

This principle is often misunderstood.

At a physical level, containing the chest does not mean collapsing the chest. It does not mean hollowing the chest or creating a rounded posture.

The real meaning is that the qi of the chest descends toward the dantian and the yao (waist). The chest remains relaxed and open, but its energy does not float upward.

The chest is contained within the whole body rather than isolated from it.

When misunderstood, practitioners often create a collapsed posture that compresses the lungs, stresses the heart, and produces long-term structural problems.

The instruction refers primarily to the movement of qi.

The energy empties from the chest and gathers in the abdominal center. This is essential because one cannot sink qi to the dantian if the qi remains floating in the chest.

The second half of the instruction, "raise the back," is equally misunderstood.

Many practitioners attempt to physically round the upper back, flare the shoulder blades, or create an exaggerated shape.

This is not the point.

It is not the back that rises. It is the spine that rises.

More importantly, it is the qi that adheres to the spine and ascends.

If the chest is not properly contained, the qi cannot descend to the dantian. If the qi does not accumulate in the dantian, it cannot rise along the spine.

Thus:

- Containing the chest causes qi to descend.
- Descending qi fills the dantian.
- Filling the dantian allows qi to rise along the spine.
- Rising along the spine reinforces the circulation of qi throughout the body.

Over time this becomes a continuous energetic circuit.

The physical posture matters because it makes the tissues open and conductive. But the posture alone is not the goal.

When these instructions are interpreted as fixed shapes rather than energetic processes, poor posture and tension inevitably result.

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## 3. Relax and Release the Waist

**(Song Yao)**

Perhaps this should be the first principle, because it may be the most important.

Every martial art seeks to connect the upper body and lower body.

The upper body contains substantial skeletal structure. The lower body contains substantial skeletal structure. Between them lies the waist and abdominal region, which contains comparatively little direct bony support.

This creates a challenge.

In external methods, the upper and lower body are often connected through muscular contraction. The core tightens and stabilizes the body.

This works.

However, Taichi seeks a different method.

Excessive contraction obstructs qi movement. If qi cannot flow, it cannot support the development of internal jin.

Therefore, if we do not connect through contraction, we must connect through lengthening.

There are only two basic ways to connect something:

- Compress it together.
- Stretch it into continuity.

Song Yao does not merely mean "relax the waist."

It means releasing the waist in such a way that it lengthens internally.

The waist opens.

The lower back lengthens.

The tissues stretch from crown to tailbone.

A subtle continuity develops through the center of the body.

Most people carry chronic shortening and tension in the lumbar region. The waist is habitually compressed, contracted, and stiff.

This is why foundational training emphasizes opening the yao.

When the waist truly releases, it does not become limp. It becomes long, connected, and alive.

Then the movement of the dantian can communicate through the entire body.

The upper and lower body become integrated.

Yin and yang appear naturally through these changes.

This is the function of Song Yao.

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## 4. Distinguish Empty and Full

The fourth essential point is often reduced to a simple idea:

> "One leg has weight and the other does not."

While this is true, it is only the most superficial level.

To distinguish empty and full means to perceive and regulate all manifestations of yin and yang throughout the body.

The source of these changes is the movement of the waist and dantian.

As the waist turns and shifts, waves of opening and closing move through the body. One area becomes substantial while another becomes insubstantial. One area fills while another empties.

*The process resembles the tides*.

As the ocean fills one shoreline, it simultaneously recedes from another. The same phenomenon appears within the body.

First we learn:

- One leg weighted, one unweighted.
- One hand active, one receptive.

Later we begin to perceive more subtle changes:

- Opening and closing.
- Rising and sinking.
- Expanding and gathering.
- Filling and emptying.

All manifestations of yin and yang must become clear.

To distinguish empty and full is not merely an intellectual exercise. It is the direct experience of these energetic transformations throughout the body.

And these transformations originate from the movement of the waist and dantian.

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## 5. Sink the Shoulders and Hang the Elbows

This principle is often translated as:

> "Sink the shoulders and drop the elbows."

I sometimes prefer to say:

> "Set the shoulders and hang the elbows."

The shoulders should rest where nature intended them to be.

Not lifted.

Not pulled backward.

Not collapsed forward.

Simply settled.

When the shoulders are correctly positioned and the surrounding musculature is relaxed and balanced, the shoulders are naturally sunk.

The hands remain alive, aware, and purposeful.

Between the shoulder and hand lies the elbow.

Regardless of the position of the arm, the elbow should always possess a downward intention.

Even when physically elevated, the feeling of hanging remains.

When the elbow ceases to hang, the shoulder immediately begins to lift and tense.

Likewise, when the shoulder loses its sunk quality, the elbow loses its downward connection.

The two functions are inseparable.

If one is wrong, the other is wrong.

When the elbow hangs and the shoulder sinks, qi can travel unimpeded through the arms into the hands.

If tension interrupts this relationship, energetic continuity is lost.

This principle requires constant attention and refinement.

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This leads naturally into the next essential instruction:

**Use intention (Yi), not force (Li).**

And that is where the internal art truly begins.

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## 6. Use Yi, Not Li

The sixth essential point is often translated as:

**Use Yi, not Li.**

**Use intention, not force.**

This is perhaps one of the most important and most misunderstood instructions in all of taichi training.

Most practitioners understand what *Li* means. Li refers to ordinary force, muscular effort, and the application of strength. The confusion usually concerns the meaning of *Yi*.

Many teachers translate Yi as intention. While this interpretation has validity, I believe that within the context of internal training, Yi can be understood more deeply as **attention**.

This distinction is critical.

If this principle is misunderstood, a ceiling is placed upon one's development from the very beginning.

Intention is directed toward the future. It seeks a particular outcome. It wants reality to become something other than what it presently is. If something is already as it is, there is no need to intend it.

Attention is different.

Attention remains with what is happening right now.

Attention observes.

Attention listens.

Attention receives.

Attention does not attempt to force reality into a predetermined shape.

This matters because attention is how we access qi.

Qi can only be experienced in the present moment. It cannot be found by projecting into the future. It reveals itself through direct awareness of what is happening now.

In this sense, intention contains an element of forcefulness.

It wants something.

It seeks a result.

It attempts to shape reality according to an idea.

Attention does none of this.

Attention simply perceives.

The moment we become attached to a preferred outcome, our sensitivity begins to diminish. We have already decided what should happen, so we stop listening to what is actually happening.

This is especially important in push-hands and taijutsu.

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A classical teaching states:

"Give up yourself and follow others."

How can we truly follow if we have already decided what is going to happen?

We cannot.

The moment we insist upon an outcome, we stop following.

The moment we stop following, we stop harmonizing.

The moment we stop harmonizing, we stop listening.

The entire training process must become saturated with attention.

Attention allows adaptation.

Attention allows sensitivity.

Attention allows change.

Attention allows harmony.

For this reason, you must remember:

**Use Yi, not Li**

This is to avoid muscular force.

These concepts are pointing toward a quality of awareness that allows us to perceive, connect, follow, and transform in real time.

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## 7. Upper and Lower Follow Each Other

The seventh essential point is often translated as:

**The upper and lower follow each other.**

Most people interpret this as coordination. They attempt to move their upper body and lower body together at the same time.

This is only the outward appearance.

The deeper principle is:

**When one-part moves, all parts move. When one-part stops, all parts stop.**

The important question is:

What is the "one part"?

In Taichi practice, that one part is the dantian expressing itself through the waist.

The center moves first.

The movement then propagates throughout the entire body.

As a result, the upper and lower body appear to follow each other.

In reality, they are both following the center.

This distinction is profound.

It is entirely possible to coordinate separate body parts mechanically while still lacking genuine internal connection.

Many practitioners move the arms and legs together. This does not necessarily mean the body is integrated.

True integration occurs when a single central movement mobilizes the entire body simultaneously.

The dantian moves.

The waist turns.

The body responds.

The upper and lower arrive together because they arise from the same source.

The body becomes unified not through coordination but through causation.

Everything follows the center.

This is why Taichi practice seeks whole-body movement rather than synchronized movement.

The practitioner no longer experiences the body as separate parts working together.

The body becomes a single integrated system.

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## 8. Internal and External Unite

The eighth essential point states:

**Internal and external are united.**

Most practitioners are familiar with the Three External Harmonies:

- Shoulders coordinate with hips.
- Elbows coordinate with knees.
- Hands coordinate with feet.

These are visible harmonies.

They can be observed from the outside.

Yet in our Taichi practice it is not defined merely by these external relationships.

The external harmonies are **what** happens.

The internal harmonies are **how** it happens.

The Three Internal Harmonies are traditionally understood as:

- Shen and Yi.
- Yi and Qi.
- Qi and Jin.

Or more simply:

- Awareness harmonizes with attention.
- Attention harmonizes with qi.
- Qi harmonizes with physical expression.

As these internal relationships mature, they naturally manifest through the body as the external harmonies.

The external structure becomes the visible expression of an invisible process.

This is why internal training is not something added later.

It is present from the very beginning.

Every exercise should be training the internal harmonies.

Every form movement should be training the internal harmonies.

Every standing practice should be training the internal harmonies.

The external harmonies provide the structure.

The internal harmonies provide the life.

When these mature together, internal and external cease to be separate.

They become one unified expression.

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## 9. Continuous and Unbroken

***The silk body emerges as the body's fascial and structural connections become integrated into one continuous whole.***

The ninth essential point is often translated as:

**Continuous and unbroken.**

At a superficial level, many people think this simply means that one movement flows smoothly into the next.

That is true.

But it is not the deeper meaning.

The real meaning is that **jin must remain continuous and unbroken.**

If any part of the body loses connection, the jin is broken at that point.

If one area ceases to participate in the silk-reeling connection, power cannot be transmitted through the whole body.

The chain has been interrupted.

The whole body must remain connected.

Jin does not alternate between having power and not having power.

Every movement contains power.

Every movement contains transformation.

Every movement contains the potential to issue force.

The body should remain alive and connected at all times.

This quality is developed through all of the previous essential points:

- Suspending from above.
- Containing the chest and raising the back.
- Releasing the waist.

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- Distinguishing empty and full.
- Sinking the shoulders and hanging the elbows.
- Using Yi rather than Li.
- Unifying upper and lower.
- Unifying internal and external.

If any one of these breaks down, continuity is weakened.

The silk no longer pulls through the body.

The power becomes fragmented.

A common mistake is to disconnect and then reconnect during movement.

Whenever this occurs, continuity has already been lost.

True Taichi power is not assembled piece by piece.

It is already present.

The body remains connected from beginning to end.

Continuity must exist in two dimensions.

**Unbroken in Space**

Every part of the body remains connected to every other part.

The pathway of power is uninterrupted.

The feet connect with the legs.

The legs connect with the waist.

The waist connects with the spine.

The spine connects with the shoulders.

The shoulders connect with the elbows.

The elbows connect with the hands.

The whole-body functions as one unit.

**Unbroken in Time**

Power is not only present at the end of a movement.

Power is present at the beginning.

Power is present throughout the movement.

Power is present at the completion of the movement.

There are no dead moments.

No gaps.

No interruptions.

The body remains continuously connected from start to finish.

This continuity arises from the fullness of qi and the uninterrupted pulling of silk throughout the entire body.

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## 10. Seek Stillness Within Movement

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The final essential point is perhaps the most profound:

**Seek stillness within movement.**

Many people assume this simply means remaining calm while moving.

Others imagine it means keeping one part of the body still while another part moves.

Neither interpretation reaches the heart of the teaching.

To understand stillness within movement, we must first understand what movement means.

Movement does not merely refer to locomotion.

It does not simply mean moving forward, backward, left, or right.

The movement being discussed is the movement of yin and yang themselves.

Empty becomes full.

Full becomes empty.

Rising becomes sinking.

Opening becomes closing.

Yin and yang continually transform into one another.

This transformation creates movement.

Yet wherever yin and yang separate, there must also be a point of balance.

That point of balance is **Zhong Ding**.

At the center of Zhong Ding is stillness.

Therefore, to seek stillness within movement is to seek Zhong Ding within all transformation.

The body moves.

The qi moves.

Yin and yang transform.

Yet at the center remains a profound stillness.

This stillness is not the absence of movement.

It is the equilibrium that exists within movement.

If we examine the Thirteen Energies, they culminate in Zhong Ding.

If we examine these Ten Essential Points, they culminate in Zhong Ding.

All genuine Taichi training ultimately leads toward this realization.

Zhong Ding is not merely posture.

It is not merely alignment.

It is the dynamic equilibrium generated through the harmonious interaction of yin and yang.

To maintain Zhong Ding is to maintain Taichi itself.

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## Closing Reflection

The Ten Essential Points are called essential for a reason.

They are not matters of style.

They are not matters of lineage.

They are not matters of preference.

Whatever form of Taichi one practices, these principles must be present.

One may understand them intellectually and still possess no Taichi.

One may memorize every point and still miss their meaning.

What matters is embodiment.

Each principle must be investigated, refined, and lived until it becomes intimate.

You must know it the same way you know your own hand.

Not as an idea.

Not as a theory.

Not as a philosophy.

But directly.

Immediately.

The intellect can understand the words.

Only practice can reveal their reality.

The deepest aspects of Taichi cannot be inherited from a book, borrowed from a teacher, or collected as concepts.

They must be discovered within the body itself.

The Ten Essential Points are not ideas to possess.

They are realities to embody.

And when they become embodied, Taichi is no longer something you do.

It becomes something you are.

**Zhong Ding (中定)** is one of the most important and yet most misunderstood concepts in Taichi.

The term is often translated as:

- **Zhong (中)** = center, middle, centrality
- **Ding (定)** = stability, equilibrium, settledness, stillness

Together, Zhong Ding can be translated as:

**Central Equilibrium**

**Centered Stability**

**Dynamic Balance**

**The Still Point at the Center of Change**

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Most people initially understand Zhong Ding as posture or alignment. They think it means keeping the spine upright and maintaining good balance.

That is only the beginning.

## The Physical Level

At the physical level, Zhong Ding means:

- The head is suspended.
- The spine is aligned.
- The weight is rooted.
- The body is balanced in all directions.

You are neither leaning nor resisting.

You are centered.

This is the level most practitioners begin with.

## The Energetic Level

At a deeper level, Zhong Ding is not merely physical alignment.

As yin and yang continually separate and reunite within the body, there is always a point of balance between them.

- Rising and sinking.
- Opening and closing.
- Empty and full.
- Expanding and gathering.

These opposites are constantly transforming.

Zhong Ding is the equilibrium point between them.

It is the axis around which change occurs.

Like the hub of a wheel.

The wheel turns.

The hub remains centered.

## The Martial Level

In push hands, Zhong Ding is the ability to remain centered while everything around you changes.

Your partner presses.

Your partner pulls.

Your partner changes.

You change.

Yet your center remains undisturbed.

Not rigid.

Not fixed.

Not resistant.

Alive and adaptive.

You neither oppose nor collapse.

You maintain the center.

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## The Spiritual Level

This is where the teaching becomes profound.

The classics speak of:

"Seeking stillness within movement."

The stillness is Zhong Ding.

Everything moves.

The body moves.

The qi moves.

The emotions move.

Thoughts move.

Circumstances move.

Yet there remains a place that is unmoving.

Not because it is frozen.

Because it is perfectly balanced.

Like the eye of a hurricane.

Movement everywhere.

Stillness at the center.

**Why It Is the Goal of our Taichi - Taijutsu**

If you examine the Thirteen Energies, they culminate in Zhong Ding.

If you examine these Ten Essential Points, they ultimately cultivate Zhong Ding.

Every principle supports it:

- Suspend the head.
- Sink the qi.
- Release the waist.
- Distinguish empty and full.
- Sink the shoulders.
- Unify upper and lower.
- Connect internal and external.
- Maintain continuity.

All of them serve one purpose:

> To establish and preserve Zhong Ding.

In that sense, Zhong Ding is not just one principle among many.

It is the result of all the other principles functioning correctly.

**A Simple Image I would describe it this way:**

> Imagine a spinning top.
>
> The faster it spins, the more still its center appears.
>
> The motion and the stillness are not opposites.
>
> The stillness exists because of perfect balance within the motion.
>
> That still center is Zhong Ding.

Or even more simply:

> **Zhong Ding is the place within yourself that does not move, even while everything else is moving.**

That is why the old masters considered it the heart of Taichi practice. It is not merely posture. It is the living experience of balance, harmony, and centered awareness amidst continuous change.

Compare Zhong Ding with rooting

This is a wonderful comparison because many practitioners mistakenly think **rooting** and **Zhong Ding** are the same thing. They're closely related, but they're not identical.

A simple way to express it is:

> **Rooting is your relationship with the ground.**
>
> **Zhong Ding is your relationship with the center.**

Or even more simply:

> **Rooting is downward.**
>
> **Zhong Ding is central.**

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## Rooting (Gen 根)

Rooting is the ability to establish a stable connection through the body into the ground.

At the physical level:

- Weight settles through the legs.
- The feet connect to the earth.
- Force can be transmitted into the ground.
- The body becomes stable and difficult to uproot.

At the energetic level:

- Qi descends.
- Qi sinks.
- The lower dantian becomes established.
- The body's center of gravity becomes calm and settled.

A tree is a useful image.

The deeper the roots, the stronger the tree's connection to the earth.

Rooting gives stability.

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## Zhong Ding (中定)

Zhong Ding is the balanced center that exists within all changes.

At the physical level:

- The spine remains organized.
- The center remains aligned.
- Balance is maintained.

At the energetic level:

- Yin and yang remain harmonized.
- Empty and full remain distinct.
- Rising and sinking remain balanced.

A spinning top is a better image for Zhong Ding.

A top may be moving very rapidly, but its center remains perfectly balanced.

Zhong Ding gives equilibrium.

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## Can You Have Rooting Without Zhong Ding?

Yes.

Many martial artists develop very strong rooting.

They are difficult to move.

Heavy.

Stable.

Grounded.

But when pushed from the correct angle they become stuck.

Their root becomes static.

They have rooting without true Zhong Ding.

This is common in beginners.

They mistake heaviness for internal skill.

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## Can You Have Zhong Ding Without Rooting?

To a degree, yes.

Many advanced practitioners can maintain a remarkable sense of central equilibrium even when stepping, moving, turning, or changing.

Their balance remains intact.

Their center remains intact.

Yet if they lack sufficient rooting, their power has no foundation.

Their center floats.

So Zhong Ding can exist conceptually without deep rooting, but it cannot fully express itself martially.

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**Relationship Between the Two**

Rooting supports Zhong Ding.

Zhong Ding organizes rooting.

They develop together.

A useful analogy is:

**Rooting = The Tree's Roots**

The roots sink downward.

They connect to the earth.

They provide stability.

**Zhong Ding = The Tree Trunk**

The trunk remains upright between earth and sky.

It organizes all movement.

It balances all forces.

Without roots the trunk falls.

Without the trunk the roots have no meaningful expression.

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## From an Internal Arts Perspective

Many teachers describe rooting as a yin quality.

It descends.

It settles.

It sinks.

Zhong Ding exists at the balance point between yin and yang.

Rooting is one of the factors that helps create Zhong Ding, but Zhong Ding also includes:

- Rising
- Sinking
- Opening
- Closing
- Empty
- Full
- Left
- Right
- Forward
- Backward

All held in dynamic balance.

In that sense:

> **Rooting is one component of Zhong Ding.**
>
> **Zhong Ding is the total equilibrium of the Taichi system.**

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# Rising Sun Martial Arts Academy

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## A Taichi Definition

**Rooting is the ability to connect to the earth without becoming fixed.**

**Zhong Ding is the ability to remain perfectly centered while everything changes around you.**

Rooting provides the foundation.

Zhong Ding provides the balance.

Together they create the living stability that is characteristic of genuine Taichi practice.

**A tree is rooted.**

**A spinning top possesses Zhong Ding.**

**A master of Taichi is both at the same time.**

Yet stability alone does not create movement. A tree may be rooted and a spinning top may remain centered, but Taichi requires the ability to transform stability into action. The mechanism that allows rooting and center to express themselves through motion is the Yao, the body's central turning axis.

In Taichi, **Yao (腰)** is usually translated as:

**Waist**

**Lumbar region**

**Lower torso**

However, these translations don't fully capture the meaning.

### The Physical Meaning

Anatomically, the yao refers to the area between the ribs and the pelvis:

- Lower back
- Waist
- Lumbar spine
- Deep abdominal region

It is the body's central turning mechanism.

When the classics say:

"The waist is the commander."

they mean that movement should originate from the body's center rather than from the hands or shoulders.

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### The Martial Meaning

The yao acts like the transmission of a vehicle.

Power generated from the legs must pass through the yao before reaching the upper body.

If the yao is stiff:

- Power becomes disconnected.
- Upper and lower cannot coordinate.
- The body becomes segmented.

If the yao is open and alive:

- Power travels through the entire body.
- Upper and lower connect.
- Whole-body movement becomes possible.

This is important to cultivate:

> **Song Yao (鬆腰)**
>
> "Relax and release the waist."

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## The Energetic Meaning

In internal training, the yao is closely related to the dantian.

The dantian stores and organizes qi.

The yao expresses and transmits that movement.

A common saying is:

> "The dantian moves, the yao turns, and the whole body follows."

The dantian is the engine.

The yao is the transmission.

The limbs are the wheels.

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## Relationship to Zhong Ding

This ties directly into our earlier discussion.

- **Rooting** develops below.
- **Zhong Ding** maintains the center.
- **Yao** allows the center to communicate with the entire body.

Without rooting, the yao has no foundation.

Without the yao, Zhong Ding cannot express itself through movement.

Without Zhong Ding, the yao becomes mere twisting.

When all three work together:

> The root sinks.
>
> Zhong Ding remains balanced.
>
> The yao turns.
>
> The whole body moves as one.

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## A Beautiful Classical Interpretation

For advanced Taichi practice, many teachers eventually stop thinking of the yao as merely the waist.

Instead, they begin to experience it as:

> **The living center through which heaven and earth meet.**

Above it is suspension and Shen.

Below it is rooting and earth.

The yao is the bridge between them.

I was taught to describe it this way:

> **The Yao is not simply the waist. It is the body's central gear. Through it, the root communicates with the hands, the dantian communicates with the limbs, and Zhong Ding expresses itself through movement.**

Understanding the role of the Yao is one thing. Learning to free it is another. Most people carry hidden tension through the waist, hips, and lower back, creating interruptions in movement, balance, and power. This is why Taichi places such emphasis on Song Yao, the art of releasing the waist without losing structure.

**Song Yao (鬆腰)** is one of the most important concepts in Taichi practice and one of the most misunderstood.

People often translate it simply as:

> **"Relax the waist."**

But that translation is not deep enough.

The character **Song (鬆)** does not mean limp, collapsed, or floppy. It means:

- Release
- Loosen
- Open
- Unbind
- Free from unnecessary tension

The character **Yao (腰)** means:

- Waist
- Lumbar region
- The body's central gear

So a better translation might be:

**"Release and open the waist."**

**"Free the waist."**

**"Allow the waist to lengthen and become connected."**

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# What Song Yao Is Not

Many practitioners hear "relax the waist" and simply let everything go slack.

That is not Song Yao.

A slack rope cannot transmit force.

A collapsed waist cannot connect the upper and lower body.

When the classics speak of Song Yao, they are describing a waist that is:

- Relaxed but alive.
- Open but structured.
- Soft but connected.

The waist is not collapsed.

It is released.

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# The Structural Meaning

The waist sits between two major skeletal structures:

- The rib cage above
- The pelvis below

The waist itself contains relatively little rigid support compared to the structures above and below.

This creates a problem:

How do we connect upper body and lower body?

Many external systems solve this through muscular contraction.

They tighten the core.

They brace.

They lock things together.

Taichi seeks another approach.

Instead of contraction, it seeks connection through lengthening.

When the waist releases properly, the lower back lengthens.

The tissues open.

The spine lengthens.

The torso becomes internally connected.

The body begins to function as one piece.

---

# The Energetic Meaning

At the energetic level, Song Yao allows qi to pass freely through the center.

If the waist is rigid:

- Qi becomes obstructed.
- The dantian cannot communicate with the limbs.
- Upper and lower disconnect.

When the waist is released:

- Qi can descend.
- Qi can rise.
- Empty and full become clear.
- Jin can travel through the entire body.

The classics often describe the waist as:

> "The commander of the body."

The dantian initiates.

The waist transmits.

The body expresses.

---

# The Martial Meaning

In application, Song Yao allows power to travel from the feet to the hands.

Without Song Yao:

- The legs generate force.
- The force gets stuck in the hips or lower back.

- The arms act independently.

With Song Yao:

- Force rises from the ground.
- Travels through the legs.
- Passes through the waist.
- Reaches the hands.

The entire body acts as one unit.

This is why many Taichi masters say:

> "The waist is the axis of all movement."

---

## Relationship to Zhong Ding

This connects directly to our discussion about Zhong Ding.

Imagine a wheel:

- **Zhong Ding** is the axle at the center.
- **Song Yao** is the hub that allows the wheel to turn smoothly.
- **Rooting** is the contact with the ground.

If the hub is stiff, the wheel cannot turn.

If the center is lost, the wheel wobbles.

If the root is lost, the wheel slips.

All three support one another.

---

## A More Advanced Understanding

At higher levels, Song Yao is not something you "do."

It becomes a condition.

The waist feels:

- Open
- Spacious
- Conductive
- Alive

The turning of the dantian naturally expresses through the waist.

Movement arises from the center rather than from the limbs.

The body begins to exhibit what the classics call:

> **"One-part moves, all parts move."**

And this is why many teachers quietly consider Song Yao to be one of the most important of the Ten Essential Points.

For our curriculum, I will summarize it this way:

> **Song Yao is the art of releasing the waist so completely that it becomes the living bridge between root and center, between dantian and limbs, allowing the whole body to move as one connected unit.**

As the waist begins to release, practitioners often discover an entirely new sensation. The body no longer feels like separate parts working independently. Instead, an unbroken thread of connection begins to emerge. The classical image used to describe this experience is "Pulling Silk."

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Note: The phrase ***"pulling silk"*** comes from the concept of **silk-reeling energy** (*Chan Si Jin*, 纏絲勁), particularly associated with Chen Taijiquan, though the principle exists throughout the internal arts.

The image is simple:

> Imagine pulling a single strand of silk from a cocoon.
>
> Pull too hard and it breaks.
>
> Pull too softly and it tangles.
>
> Pull steadily and continuously and the strand unwinds without interruption.

This image describes how force, qi, and connection should move through the body.

## Physical Meaning

At the most basic level, pulling silk means maintaining a continuous stretch through the body's connective pathways.

For example:

- The fingers extend.
- The wrist remains connected.
- The elbow hangs.
- The shoulder sinks.
- The spine lengthens.
- The waist turns.
- The legs root.

Each part remains connected to the next.

Nothing disconnects.

Nothing collapses.

Nothing becomes rigid.

There is a subtle feeling as though every part of the body is gently pulling away from every other part while remaining connected.

---

## Song Yao and Pulling Silk

This is where your earlier question about Song Yao becomes important.

When the yao releases:

- The spine lengthens.

- The kua opens.
- The torso develops internal stretch.

That stretch is the beginning of silk pulling.

Not muscular tension.

Not rigidity.

An alive, elastic connection.

Without Song Yao, the silk breaks at the waist.

With Song Yao, the silk can pass through the body's center.

This is why internal teachers often say:

> "Release to connect."

The connection is not created through contraction.

It is created through lengthening.

---

## In Walking

Walking provides a perfect example.

Most people move a foot first and drag the body after it or just the opposite.

Silk pulling works differently.

The center releases.

The dantian shifts.

The yao turns.

The weight changes.

The foot simply follows.

The entire body feels connected from the standing foot to the stepping hand.

There is a continuous thread running through the body.

That thread is the feeling of pulling silk.

---

## In Martial Application

When issuing power:

A beginner often creates force in segments.

- Legs push.
- Waist turns.
- Arm strikes.

These happen as separate events.

The silk breaks.

An advanced practitioner feels:

- Feet
- Legs
- Waist
- Spine
- Shoulder
- Elbow
- Hand

all participating in one continuous action.

Power arrives as a whole-body wave.

*Only through experience can you understand and cultivate presence in your practice.*

The silk never breaks.

---

## Relationship to Jin

> "If the silk does not pull, the jin is broken."

When the connection is lost anywhere:

- The elbow disconnects.
- The waist tightens.
- The shoulder lifts.
- The root collapses.

The silk breaks.

Consequently, the jin becomes fragmented.

When the silk remains continuous, jin remains continuous.

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## Relationship to Zhong Ding

An interesting way to compare them:

- **Rooting** provides the anchor.
- **Song Yao** provides the release.
- **Pulling Silk** provides the connection.
- **Zhong Ding** provides the balance.

All four are occurring at the same time.

The root sinks.

The silk stretches.

The center remains balanced.

The body moves as one.

At first, Pulling Silk is experienced as connection. Over time, that connection becomes increasingly alive and tangible. Practitioners begin to notice a subtle continuity flowing through posture, breathing, awareness, and movement. Traditional Chinese arts refer to this living continuity as Qi.

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## Power (Jìn, 勁) in Taichi Training

In Taichi, **power** does not simply mean muscular strength. The traditional term is **Jìn (勁)**, which refers to **trained, refined power** generated through whole-body connection, alignment, relaxation, and intent.

A practical definition is:

**Power (Jìn) is the efficient expression of coordinated body movement directed by intention and supported by qi.**

## Strength vs. Power

**Li (力) - Strength**

- Raw muscular force
- Localized effort
- Can create tension

- Often relies on brute force

**Jìn (勁) - Taichi Power**

- Whole-body connection
- Rooted in the legs
- Directed by the waist
- Expressed through relaxed structure
- Efficient rather than forceful

The Taiji Classics state:

"The root is in the feet, issued through the legs, directed by the waist, and expressed through the hands."

Rooting, Zhong Ding, Song Yao, Pulling Silk, Qi, and Jin are often studied as separate concepts. In practice they are never separate. Their value is revealed only when interacting with another person. Push Hands provides a living laboratory where these principles become tangible and observable.

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**Qi (Chi, 氣/气)** is a foundational concept in Chinese philosophy, medicine, and internal arts such as **Taiji (Tai Chi)** and **Qigong**.

A simple definition is:

> **Qi is the vital life force or energy that animates and connects all living things.**

In traditional Chinese thought, qi is not merely physical energy. It is the dynamic force that flows through nature, the body, the emotions, the mind, and the universe itself. It is the movement behind growth, change, health, and vitality.

Qi is cultivated through:

- Relaxation (Song)
- Correct alignment
- Breathing
- Intent (Yi)
- Slow, connected movement

A common saying in Taiji is:
**"Yi leads the Qi, and Qi moves the body."**

Qi alone, however, is not the goal. Internal development must ultimately express itself through functional movement. When intention guides Qi, and Qi permeates the body's structure, that connection can manifest as refined power. In Taichi, this trained power is called Jin.

***The silk body emerges as the body's fascial and structural connections become integrated into one continuous whole.***

Principles have little value unless they can be embodied. Push Hands allows us to feel what previously existed only as ideas. Through contact with another person, connection becomes measurable, balance becomes observable, and the quality of our movement is immediately revealed.

**A Curriculum Definition**

*Only through experience can you understand and cultivate presence in your practice.*

For our Taichi study guide, use this order:

**Pulling silk is the continuous internal stretch that connects the entire body without rigidity. Through Song Yao, rooting, and Zhong Ding, the practitioner develops an unbroken thread of connection from foot to hand, allowing qi and jin to move through the whole body as a single integrated unit.**

**Pulling silk is the feeling that every movement is gently unwinding from the center while remaining continuously connected from beginning to end.**

## The Applications.

During Push Hands drills, once contact is secured, the grip or touch should soften while remaining connected through the entire body.

The hand alone no longer holds the opponent. The whole body participates in the connection

Once connection has been established, the next question becomes how change unfolds through that connection. Whether practicing forms, Push Hands, martial application, or daily life, movement follows recognizable patterns. Four of the most useful are Rising, Continuing, Turning, and Closing.

These four words describe more than movement. In Taichi or Taijutsu they represent phases of change that occur in the body, mind, qi, and relationship with an opponent. They are found throughout the form, push hands, applications, and even daily life.

## Rising (Shēng 升)

Rising is the emergence of energy and intention.

Physically, rising occurs when the body expands from the ground upward. The legs root, the spine lengthens, and the crown point lifts naturally toward heaven. The movement should not feel forced or stiff. It is like a young bamboo shoot growing toward sunlight.

In application, rising can uproot an opponent's balance, disrupt their structure, or create space. It often appears when issuing upward force, lifting, receiving pressure, or transitioning from a lower to a higher position.

Internally, rising is the awakening of awareness. Before any technique manifests, there is a subtle emergence of intention.

**The Image:** Mist rising from a mountain valley at dawn.

**Practice Question:** Can I rise without tension? Can my body feel lighter while remaining rooted?

*Only through experience can you understand and cultivate presence in your practice.*

## Continuing (Xù 續)

Continuing is uninterrupted flow.

Many practitioners learn movements but pause unconsciously between them. Taichi – Taijutsu teaches that there is no stopping. One movement becomes the next without breaking connection.

Physically, continuing means maintaining connection from foot to hand, from one posture into another, without losing structure.

In push hands, continuing means following the opponent without interruption. A change in pressure is met with a seamless response.

Mentally, continuing develops perseverance and patience. The mind does not become distracted by success or failure but simply remains present.

It is often said:

> "Like a river flowing around stones."

The water never stops because obstacles appear.

**The Image :** A river flowing endlessly through a canyon.

**Practice Question:** Where does my movement stop? Where does my awareness leave the present moment?

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## Turning (Zhuǎn 轉)

Turning is transformation.

Taichi – Taijutsu teaches that nothing remains fixed. Yin becomes Yang. Full becomes empty. Attack becomes defense. Defense becomes opportunity.

Physically, turning occurs through waist rotation, spiraling energy, and changing direction. The waist acts as a commander, guiding the body's transformations.

In application, turning allows force to be redirected rather than opposed. Rather than colliding with strength, we transform it.

Internally, turning reflects adaptability.

When conditions change:

- Fear becomes courage.
- Confusion becomes understanding.
- Resistance becomes acceptance.

The experienced practitioner never becomes trapped because they know how to turn.

**The Image:** A hawk circling on a thermal current.

**Practice Question:** Can I transform incoming force without resisting it? Can I change without losing my center?

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## Closing (Hé 合)

*Only through experience can you understand and cultivate presence in your practice.*

Closing is return, completion, and integration.

Many students think closing means ending. In Taichi, Taijutsu, closing is the gathering and returning of what has been developed.

Physically, energy returns to the center. The body settles, sinks, and becomes calm. Excess effort dissolves.

In application, closing may conclude an engagement by controlling the opponent, creating distance, or restoring balance.

Internally, closing means returning to stillness. The lessons of practice are gathered and stored.

The final movement of a Taichi form is not merely the end of training. It is the return to the original state from which training began.

Like a circle, the ending becomes the beginning of the next cycle.

**The Image:** The sun disappears beyond the horizon while its warmth remains.

**Practice Question:** What have I gathered from today's practice? Have I returned to stillness?

Although these principles can be studied individually, they are never truly separate. Like the seasons, they continuously transform into one another, forming a cycle of emergence, expression, transformation, and return.

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## Together

These four principles form a complete cycle:

**Rise** → Energy emerges.

**Continue** → Energy flows.

**Turn** → Energy transforms.

**Close** → Energy returns.

Then the cycle begins again.

In a deeper sense, they describe an entire human life:

- We rise into the world.
- We continue through experience.
- We turn through challenges and transformation.
- We close by returning what we have learned to those who follow.

A Taichi master sees these principles not merely in the form, but in rivers, seasons, relationships, and the rhythm of life itself.

In this curriculum remember:

**The form is not teaching us how to move.**

**The form is teaching us how change unfolds.**

*Only through experience can you understand and cultivate presence in your practice.*

## Reminder of definitions:

The form is not teaching us how to move.

The form is teaching us how change unfolds.

**Throughout this curriculum, certain terms appear repeatedly. They are more than vocabulary words. They are markers pointing toward direct experience. Before concluding, let us briefly revisit their essential meanings.**

***Taijutsu*** is the cultivation of natural body movement that allows intention to be expressed through an integrated and adaptable structure.

***Taichi*** is the same art represented by different spellings. The term Taiji (太極) is commonly translated as "Supreme Ultimate" or "Great Polarity," describing the harmonious relationship of Yin and Yang that underlies Chinese philosophy and internal martial arts. As your understanding grows through study and practice, you will gradually encounter more of the traditional terminology and principles that give depth and meaning to this path.

Make this your daily practice and the quality of your life will improve.

**Progress in Taichi does not come from collecting techniques or memorizing terminology. It comes from returning to these principles again and again until they become part of how you stand, move, think, and live. Rooting becomes stability. Zhong Ding becomes balance. Song Yao becomes freedom. Pulling Silk becomes connection. Qi becomes vitality. Jin becomes effortless power. Over time, what began as practice becomes simply the way you meet the world.**

**Every return reveals something new. Every step deepens understanding.**

**Keep Going.**

# Rising Sun Martial Arts Academy

*Only through experience can you understand and cultivate presence in your practice.*




## About the Author

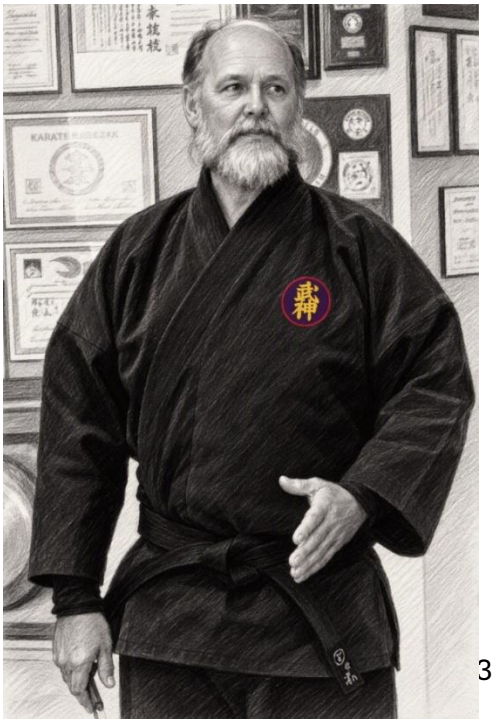


**Jim Risinger** is a lifelong student of the martial, healing, and spiritual arts with more than fifty years of training and practice. A licensed **Shidōshi** in **Bujinkan Budō Taijutsu**, he trained under **Sōke Dr. Masaaki Hatsumi** and **Dai Shihan Ronald Blackwood** and has spent more than twenty years following the path of the **Yamabushi and Shugendō traditions of Japan** through mountain training, pilgrimage, and meditation.

Jim is also a **Master Practitioner and Teacher of Shin Shin Kaizen Usui Reiki Ryōhō**, a **Certified Massage Therapist**, and a dedicated student of the **Amatsu Tatara traditions**.

As **Dōjō-chō of Ohoko Dōjō** in Orcutt, California, he teaches a unique integration of martial arts, healing arts, natural law, and personal development through the path of the **Scholar, Warrior, and Sage**.

**His life's work is dedicated to helping others awaken their potential, cultivate wisdom, and return to their Original Self.**



*Only through experience can you understand and cultivate presence in your practice.*

***A shy child becomes a teacher.***
***A student becomes a mentor.***
***A warrior becomes a healer.***
***A traveler becomes a sage.***

***We keep going.***

## *Concealment for Freedom*

### *The Journey of the Scholar, Warrior, Sage*